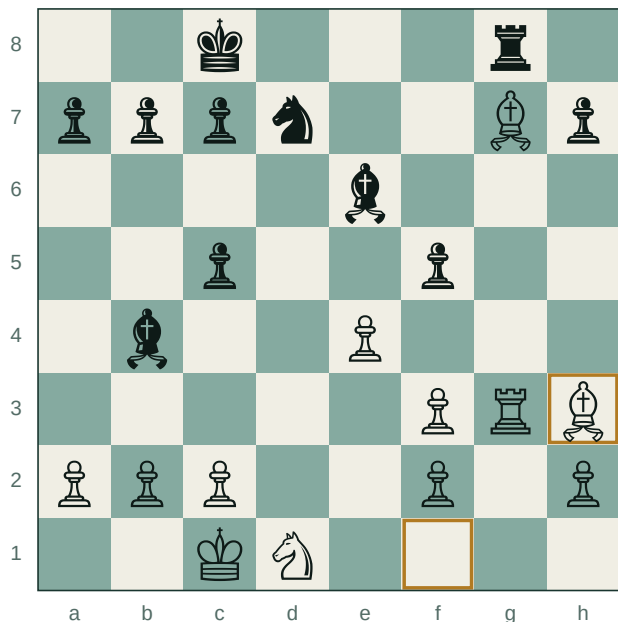


Capture the defender: Black, move 17

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 17.Bh3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

17...f4 18. Bxe6 fxg3 19. fxg3 Rxc3

17...f4 The pawn moves from f5 to f4. The changed line means the bishop on e6 attacks the bishop on h3. Recorded reply: **18.Bxe6**.

18...fxg3 The pawn captures the rook on g3. Recorded reply: **19.fxg3**.

19...Rxc3 The rook captures the bishop on c3.

At the end, nominal material is White 13 / Black 16 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +4:** the balance goes from -1 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on c1. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.